

Chapter 5

Proposed Work

Completion of the proposed work will result in a complete analysis, from start to finish, of improved DNP group parameters for thermal fission of ^{235}U and the effects of these improved parameters on transient simulations. MoSDeN, which will be completed with this work, will serve as a tool to investigate the DNP group parameters with MSR physical phenomena included. The proposed work is not exhaustive, and will not investigate every fissile nuclide, nor every irradiation energy. Work which is deemed interesting yet not critical is included in Section 5.4.

The critical work includes developing the 0D flow model, validating and verifying the results of the 0D flow model, generating improved group spectra along with the DNP group parameters, and finally using the DNP group parameters in transient simulations. The non-critical work includes development of the spatially resolved model, uncertainty tracking of MSR physical phenomena in the DNP group parameters, and investigation into the effects of varying the incident neutron energy spectrum on the DNP group parameters.

Figure 5.1 shows the critical work path, divided into development, simulation, writing, and review categories. The categories which require more focus are development and writing, whereas simulation and review is generally a more passive process. Most tasks generally take one month, but three tasks are assumed to take two months: development of the MSRE Moltres model, running the various MSRE transients, and writing the results and conclusions chapters. Development of the Moltres model is expected to take longer because there may be unexpected issues with the meshing of the upper and lower plena, data collection, or model development itself. The MSRE transient simulations are given two months of simulation time because there are 12 transient simulations for safety, security, and safeguards simulations. These transient simulations also require five transport solves: three for standard MSRE operation prior to a transient with higher and lower temperatures, one with one SQ removal of ^{235}U over one year, and one with one SQ removal of Pu over one year. The results chapter is given two months because there will be many new results to discuss, whereas the other chapters will not have significant changes.

5.1 0D Flow Model

The new model which will be developed beyond the 0D scaled model is the 0D flow model. The 0D scaled model only generates saturation irradiation results, scales the flux and chemical removal based on the fraction of salt in-core and ex-core, and does not track decays of nuclides into DNPs during the decay of the sample after irradiation. However, the 0D scaled model offers a fast simulation, which does enable rapid development and simulation of many different parameters with ease.

The 0D flow model improves the fidelity of the 0D scaled model by offering both saturation and pulse irradiation

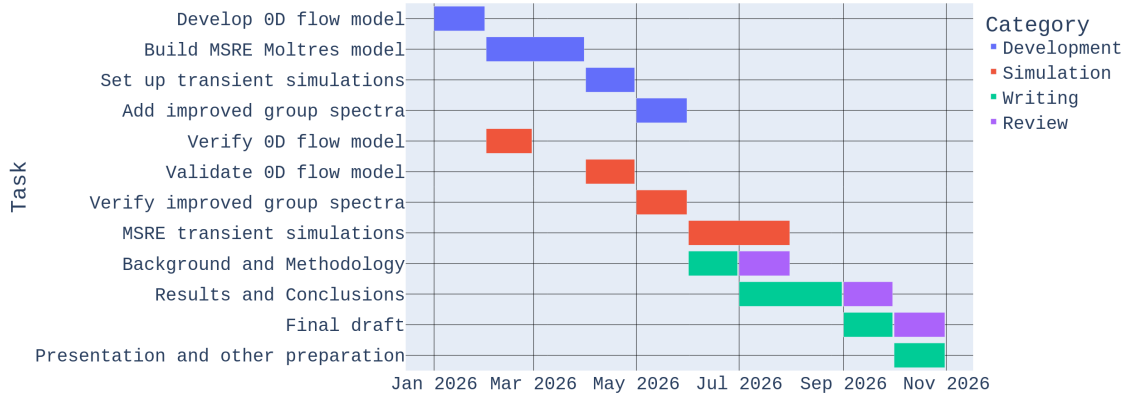


Figure 5.1: Gantt chart of proposed work and the time frame for each part of that work.

results, handles in-core and ex-core regions in time rather than simply scaling the flux, and enables tracking of decay parents for DNPs. There is also the option of using the 0D scaled model with the scaled flux approximation but with the decay chain modeled. The cost of this improved fidelity is an increased computational cost, but it is still not exceedingly expensive and can be run on a desktop. The neutron transport solve is relatively inexpensive, as the model only requires a fixed-source irradiation of the sample.

5.1.1 Least Squares Residual Treatment

A key aspect of the methodology is combining pulse and saturation irradiation DNP group parameters. One approach, used by Brady and Keepin et al., is combining two different fits after they have been generated. Brady uses the group 5 and 6 parameters from the pulse irradiation with the remaining parameters from the saturation irradiation to form the six DNP group parameters [25]. Keepin et al. fit four groups with each irradiation, and then renormalize at the second group [87].

Another approach is the Levenberg-Marquardt method, which combines pulse and saturation irradiation data [102, 111, 117]. This method of fitting DNP group parameters to both datasets simultaneously may yield more accurate results. This can also be accomplished using the trust region reflective (TRF) approach, which allows for bounds to be included for the parameters [26].

The proposed methods to compare are the current method, the Levenberg-Marquardt method, and the TRF method. The new methods minimize the residual of the form:

$$r = \min_x \left\| \frac{A_p x - b_p}{b_p + \epsilon} + \frac{A_s x - b_s}{b_s + \epsilon} \right\|_2^2, \quad (5.1)$$

where

- r = the residual of the problem [-]
- A_p = the pulse irradiation coefficient matrix [s^{-1}]
- b_p = the pulse irradiation delayed neutron count rate [$n \cdot s^{-1}$]
- A_s = the saturation irradiation coefficient matrix [s^{-1}]
- b_s = the saturation irradiation delayed neutron count rate [$n \cdot s^{-1}$]
- x = the solution vector containing group yields [-]
- ϵ = a small value to avoid division by zero
 $= 1 \times 10^{-12}$.

This formulation simultaneously treats the pulse and saturation irradiation data, generating improved DNP group parameters which fit both sets of delayed neutron count rates.

The results of this analysis will be used to evaluate which method can provide a solution with the least computational cost while also generating accurate group parameters. The group parameters will be evaluated by calculating the l^2 -norm of the residual for the least squares problem using the improved DNP group parameters over all times for both pulse and saturation irradiations.

5.1.2 Data Source Analysis

Huynh et al. compare the effects of cumulative fission yields and emission probabilities from Joint Evaluated Fission and Fusion (JEFF), ENDF, and Japanese Evaluated Nuclear Data Library (JENDL) on the total delayed neutron yield [79]. A similar comparison can also be found in the JEFF report 17 [11]. Mathieu et al. investigate additional datasets, including the National Nuclear Data Center (NNDC) website (which sources data from Evaluated Nuclear Structure Data File (ENSDF)) and various data compilations [112, 134, 8, 153].

These comparisons can be expanded to include the IAEA database, NNDC website, JEFF, ENDF, JENDL, ENSDF, and other data compilations for emission probabilities (delayed neutron branching ratios), half-lives, fission yields, and cross sections. Comparing these data sources clarifies the uncertainty caused by differences in the data. Table 5.1 shows the data sources used in the comparison. The "Concentration" column refers to data including fission yields and cross-sections that affect the DNP concentration term. Although half-lives also influence concentration, data sources without a concentration contribution provide only half-life and emission probability data. Audi et al., Pfeiffer and Kratz, and Rudstam et al. present data from the literature rather than official databases. Audi et al. use ENSDF, Atomic Mass Evaluation (AME), experimental data from the literature, and trends in neighboring nuclides. Pfeiffer and Kratz present experimental data, an update to the Kratz Herrmann formula (KHF), and data from a unified macroscopic-microscopic model within the quasi-particle random-phase approximation (QRPA). Rudstam et al. present experimental data.

Table 5.1: Various data sources as well as the data which they contain.

Data name	Year	Source	Half-life	Emission probability	Concentration
IAEA database	2018	[49]	Yes	Yes	No
JEFF 3.3	2017	[137]	Yes	Yes	Yes
ENDF/B-VIII.0	2018	[29]	Yes	Yes	Yes
JENDL-5	2021	[82]	Yes	Yes	Yes
ENSDF	2025	[54]	Yes	Yes	No
Audi et al.	2003	[8]	Yes	Yes	No
Pfeiffer and Kratz	2002	[134]	Yes	Yes	No
Rudstam et al.	1993	[153]	Yes	Yes	No

The expected outcome is that recently updated data and official databases will be more accurate than collections from the literature. Recent data should be more accurate due to improved equipment and measurement techniques. Official databases are expected to be more reliable, as they have many users reporting errors and have undergone extensive development over time. Investigating these data sources and comparing the DNP group parameters generated from each will be useful when analyzing uncertainty. If the differences are large, understanding the uncertainty propagation will be important. If the differences are negligible, this will simplify further uncertainty analysis.

5.1.3 Verification and Validation

Verifying and validating the DNP group parameters is essential to ensure their practical utility. Verification with the literature is important to ensure that the fundamental approach is working as expected. Since the literature does not contain DNP group parameters which include MSR physical phenomena, this verification with the literature will only be for the stationary solve.

After this, although the group parameters are verified with the literature, that does not necessarily mean they capture all physical phenomena of interest. Validation identifies potential weaknesses in the approach by highlighting discrepancies between predicted and experimental results.

Verification of the DNP group parameters will be of the same form as in Section 4.3. It has already been shown that these results should have a percent difference of 9% for thermal fission in ^{235}U for JEFF-3.1.1 data, so a similar percent difference can be expected for other datasets [112]. Results will vary based on the source of the data, but the DNP group parameters should closely match the results from the literature.

Validation of the DNP group parameters is conducted through the MSRE pump start-up and coast-down experimental data. This data assesses the accuracy of the group parameters in modeling reactivity changes from DNPs [139]. The validation requires modeling the MSRE core and upper and lower plena in Moltres [60]. The reactivity effects of the DNPs are calculated for both transients using static and improved DNP group parameters. The improved group parameters are expected to predict reactivity more accurately as they account for more physical phenomena in the MSRE. If neither set of reactivity responses aligns with the experimental results, then there is an issue in the kinetics simulation, as Moltres has previously demonstrated the ability to model these transients [142, 128]. These transients have also been evaluated using other tools, providing additional comparison [56, 46]. If the static group parameters predict reactivity more accurately than the improved group parameters, this suggests an issue with the improved group parameter formulation. The issue must be resolved before proceeding, as the improved DNP group parameters should provide higher accuracy in MSR modeling.

5.2 Improved Group Spectra

The delayed neutron energy spectra, χ_d is important for accurate prediction of reactor kinetics [43]. This can be seen in the equation for the effective delayed neutron fraction in Equation (2.32), recreated here as:

$$\beta_{eff} = \frac{\int \Phi^\dagger \chi_d \beta \bar{v} \Sigma_f \Phi dE d\vec{\Omega} d\vec{r}}{\int \Phi^\dagger \chi \bar{v} \Sigma_f \Phi dE d\vec{\Omega} d\vec{r}}.$$

Because the DNP group yields and half-lives are affected by the MSR physical phenomena, it follows that the DNP group spectra are also affected.

The methodology to evaluate the delayed neutron spectra is discussed in Section 2.1.2. The DNP group spectra will be generated using the half-life grouping and fractional grouping methods. The DNP group spectra will then be compared with the spectra generated from a stationary problem with no chemical removal to determine the effect of MSR phenomena on the spectra.

5.3 Transient Simulations

Transient simulations are critical for validating the DNP group parameters using MSRE transients and for investigating transients affecting security, safety, and safeguards design decisions. Section 3.5 discusses the proposed simulations in detail.

For safety design, the ULOF, UTOP, ULOHS, and FSOC are investigated for various reactor parameters to assess the impact of the improved DNP group parameters. For security design, sabotage-initiated transients are assumed to build off those studied for safety design. For safeguards design, comparisons are made between diversion scenarios. The diversion scenarios alter the fuel composition, affecting the effective delayed neutron fraction and reactor behavior during transients [190]. The improved DNP group parameters will be used to investigate the SNM removal which could remain undetected while using previous DNP group parameters.

The kinetics simulations will use Moltres and the MSRE to demonstrate how the DNP group parameters affect reactivity and temperature responses in various scenarios. These results can be compared with other analyses from the literature [73, 171]. The results will identify which transients are more sensitive to the improved data and highlight potential concerns. A PRK model can also be used for simple reactivity insertion tests with uncertainty tracking to more straightforwardly demonstrate differences between the DNP group parameters.

5.4 Future Work

This section contains various work that would be useful and interesting extensions of the proposed work. The three main categories of potential future work include development of a spatially resolved model for improved DNP group parameters, tracking of additional contributors to uncertainty, and sensitivity of DNP group parameters to varying incident neutron energy spectra. Additional miscellaneous work of interest could also include:

- Using a sinusoidal flux profile instead of a Heaviside function for the derivation given in Appendix A.
- Direct comparison of exponential stripping, least squares, and set half-life DNP group parameter fitting methods.
- More intermediate models between the 0D scaled and 0D flow models, with simplified decay chains and incorporation of cross-section data.

- Investigate if there may be a way to structure DNP group parameters such that fuel salt movement is accounted for in the delayed neutron count rate (capturing circulation in the parameters themselves).
- Inclusion of the effects of photofission.

5.4.1 Spatially Resolved Model

Although the 0D flow model provides useful insights, it does not provide a high level of fidelity for any specific geometry. A spatially resolved model will be developed to evaluate the accuracy of the 0D flow model. This model verifies whether the 0D flow model produces sufficiently accurate DNP group parameters. Section 3.2.3 discusses the spatially resolved model in detail. This spatially resolved model will compare multiple levels of fidelity for generating DNP group parameters: 0D flow model using cumulative fission yields, 0D flow model with depletion, spatially resolved flow model using cumulative fission yields, and spatially resolved flow model with depletion. Each step increases computational cost, so if a simpler method generates DNP group parameters with negligible differences, it will be used preferentially.

The process for comparing the 0D flow model and the spatially resolved model is as follows: the spatially resolved model runs and generates DNP group parameters and residence times, the residence times are used to feed into the 0D flow model, the resulting DNP group parameters are compared between the two models. If the results are within the uncertainty bounds of each other, then this indicates that the 0D flow model only needs residence time data for a given MSR to generate the DNP group parameters. If they do not match, then a spatially resolved approach will be necessary to properly generate the MSR DNP group parameters.

Sensitivity to Number of DNPs

The number of DNPs to track is of particular interest for the spatially resolved flow model. The 0D flow model's computational cost increases negligibly with more DNPs, while the spatially resolved flow model requires significantly more memory and operations to track each DNP over space and time. To improve computational efficiency, minimizing the number of DNPs is desirable. If the 0D flow model generates DNP group parameters with negligible differences compared to the spatially resolved flow model, minimizing the number of DNPs becomes less critical. However, it is of interest to optimize the spatially resolved flow model for potential future analyses which could include spatially resolved reprocessing and other effects.

The impact of each DNP is given in Equation (2.27), replicated here:

$$\tilde{v}_{d,i} = P_{n,i} \lambda_i N_{i,0}.$$

Dividing $\tilde{v}_{d,i}$ by the total delayed neutron yield, $\tilde{v}_d$, provides the relative contribution of each DNP to the total delayed neutron yield. The DNPs with the most impact can be modeled preferentially to determine the minimum number of DNPs to model with negligible changes to the DNP group parameters. A full sensitivity study will be conducted to determine a reasonable number of DNPs to include in the spatially resolved flow model.

Reactor Generalization

One of the desired outcomes for this work is formulation of DNP group parameters for MSRs which can be applied generally. If the DNP group parameters can be applied generally to different systems with similar residence times, then the amount of computational work required is drastically reduced. However, it is necessary that sufficient evidence is provided demonstrating that the improved parameters are identical for different MSRs.

Specifically, the MSRE and the MSFR will be simulated using the spatially resolved model [147, 28]. The models will be adjusted such that the in-core and ex-core residence times are identical for each. The result will be a set of group parameters for two distinct reactors but with the same residence time tabulations. Instead of calculating the neutron flux, both reactors will be given an incident neutron energy spectrum for irradiating the sample. The impact of the incident neutron energy spectra is discussed in Section 5.4.3, so differences caused by the spectra will not be studied in this section. Additionally, the fuel salt and fuel temperature in the MSFR will be replaced with those from the MSRE.

The two different reactor simulations will have all of the same input parameters aside from the geometry and thermal-hydraulic parameters. If the DNP group parameters have negligible differences, then the geometry and thermal-hydraulic parameters are not necessary when generating the group parameters. Instead, all that is needed are the other input parameters, meaning the work does not need to be replicated for every different reactor geometry and thermal-hydraulic configuration. If the DNP group parameters have non-negligible differences, then each MSR needs to have DNP group parameters generated for its own specific geometry and flow conditions. Further investigation may also be warranted to determine if there is potential for a reduced order model in which one or two parameters which could be used to capture these differences, thus reducing the total amount of work necessary to model all MSR designs.

5.4.2 MSR Uncertainties

Several sources of uncertainty are considered, including half-lives, emission probabilities, cross-sections, and fission yields. These uncertainties propagate into the DNP group and kinetics parameters [141]. However, uncertainties also arise from MSR physical phenomena, including flow rate and reprocessing rates, where the reprocessing rate is correlated with the flow rate. These uncertainties are important because they propagate to the DNP group parameters, which affect the reactor's response to different transients. It is important to understand this for safety, security, and safeguards design, as the design should account for these uncertainties. In particular, uncertainties of interest are in the residence times and chemical removal rates.

The residence time correlates linearly with the flow rate, which is dependent on the temperature. Although the flow rate would also have uncertainty based on variance in the pump, this uncertainty is considered outside the scope of this work. The temperature affects fuel salt density, buoyant force, and viscosity, all influencing the flow rate and residence time. The temperature is influenced by the fission rate, which has uncertainties from the flux and fission cross section. For the 0D flow model, the residence time uncertainties can be conservatively approximated by treating the difference between the inlet and outlet temperatures as the temperature uncertainty. Assuming a constant mass flow rate, the density change due to the large temperature uncertainty provides a velocity uncertainty, which determines the variance in the residence time. If this conservative approach to temperature uncertainty results in negligible residence time uncertainty, it can be neglected for the spatially resolved flow model. Otherwise, the spatially resolved flow model can account for this uncertainty using the STOCHASTIC TOOLS module to directly determine residence time uncertainties. The STOCHASTIC TOOLS module is a toolbox designed for performing stochastic analysis for MOOSE-based applications. The STOCHASTIC TOOLS module enables setting a range of temperatures and simulating each temperature, which can be used to generate a histogram of residence times as a function of core temperature.

The chemical removal uncertainty is challenging to treat, as there are different chemical processes for removing elements, such as sparging the fuel salt in the core, filtering elements with a nickel filter, and removing elements via liquid-liquid reductive extraction [156]. The removal efficiency of xenon in a gas separation system is given by

[130, 156] as:

$$\epsilon = \frac{1 - e^{-k_L a A_C L \left(\frac{1}{Q_{salt}} + \frac{RT}{H} \frac{1}{Q_{He}} \right)}}{1 + \frac{RT}{H} \frac{Q_{salt}}{Q_{He}}}, \quad (5.2)$$

where

R = the universal gas constant [$L \cdot Pa \cdot mol^{-1} \cdot K^{-1}$]

T = the salt temperature [K]

H = Henry's law constant for solute gas [$Pa \cdot mol^{-1} \cdot L$]

Q_{salt} = the volumetric salt flow rate [$m^3 \cdot s^{-1}$]

Q_{He} = the volumetric helium flow rate [$m^3 \cdot s^{-1}$]

k_L = the liquid phase mass transfer coefficient [$m \cdot s^{-1}$]

a = the gas-liquid interfacial area per unit volume [m^{-1}]

A_C = the contactor cross-section [m^2]

L = the contractor length [m].

The liquid-liquid reductive extraction, such as with bismuth, has distribution coefficients and equilibrium constants dependent on the element, temperature, and concentration [119]. In general, an increase in the temperature leads to an increased distribution coefficient and a decreased equilibrium constant. The distribution coefficient represents the ratio of the bismuth phase concentration to the salt phase concentration, and can be thought of as an efficiency term that is multiplied with the mass flow rate to determine the removal rate. However, the distribution coefficient changes with temperature and flow rate differently for each element and fuel salt used.

Propagating the uncertainty in the chemical removal of elements from the fuel salt is challenging, as there are many variables to consider. These include the fuel salt composition, flow rate, redox potential, hydrostatic pressure, interfacial tension, and temperature [165, 180]. Thus, generic equations are not formulated for each possible combination of variables. Instead, only the chemical removal of noble gases and noble metals from the MSRE are investigated [106]. The noble gases are actively pumped out via the off-gas system while noble metals, including molybdenum, technetium, ruthenium, rhodium, palladium, silver, and antimony plate out via reduction by UF_6 . Some elements, specifically selenium, niobium, and tellurium, vary in their behavior. These elements only sometimes plates out based on the redox potential of the salt; a well reduced salt causes them to plate out, otherwise they act as salt seekers [85, 106].

The removal rate, λ_r , of noble gases from the pump bowl via the off-gas system is [84, 106]:

$$\lambda_r = \frac{\dot{V}}{V} \epsilon, \quad (5.3)$$

where

$\dot{V}$ = the salt flow rate through the gas-liquid separator loop [$m^3 \cdot s^{-1}$]

V = the total volume of salt in the primary loop [m^3]

ϵ = the removal efficiency [-].

For the MSRE, the values are a salt flow rate of 0.003153, a total salt volume of 1.996, and a removal efficiency of

0.026 [147]. For the 0D flow model, this removal occurs while the sample is in the ex-core region and stops while the sample is in the in-core region. This is because the removal occurs in the pump bowl and not inside the core. For the spatially resolved flow model, this removal also occurs in the ex-core region, treated in the same way as the 0D flow model.

The removal rate, $\lambda_{i,l,r}$, of noble metal i to waste stream l via plate-out is [106]:

$$\lambda_{i,l,r} = \frac{h_{i,l} A_l}{V}, \quad (5.4)$$

where

$h_{i,l}$ = the mass transfer rate of element i to waste stream l [$m \cdot s^{-1}$]

A_l = the surface area of waste stream l [m^2].

The removal of noble metals does not occur in a single region, unlike the noble gas removal. Instead, there is a distribution of noble metals: 50% are in the hastalloy-N surfaces in the loop, 49% are in the ex-core region, and 1% are in the graphite surfaces in the in-core region [85]. Because 99% of the plate-out occurs in the ex-core region, the removal can be treated as occurring only in the ex-core region. The surface areas and mass transfer rates for the noble metals are given in Table 5.2, recreated from [106].

Table 5.2: Noble metal mass transfer rates, surface areas, and resulting removal rates (recreated from [106] with data from [85]).

Component	$h_{i,l}$ [$m \cdot s^{-1}$]	A_l [m^2]	$\lambda_{i,l,r}$ [s^{-1}]
HX	4.657×10^{-5}	2.93×10^1	6.827×10^{-4}
Fuel loop piping, core and pump volute	1.041×10^{-4}	6.60×10^0	3.441×10^{-4}
Core wall cooling annulus	4.318×10^{-5}	1.43×10^1	3.095×10^{-4}
Core graphite (exposed to salt)	5.334×10^{-6}	1.36×10^2	3.637×10^{-4}
Miscellaneous	-	-	1.695×10^{-4}
Bubbles	4.233×10^{-4}	3.205×10^1	6.7978×10^{-3}
Total	-	-	8.6674×10^{-3}

5.4.3 Incident Neutron Energy Spectra

The incident neutron energy spectrum directly affects the DNP group parameters [23]. However, it would be computationally expensive to generate new DNP group parameters for every unique incident neutron energy spectrum. Some coarser resolution is required, so it is of interest to determine a reasonable categorization of the DNP group parameters for different energy spectra.

This sensitivity study will investigate different levels of fidelity for organizing the energy spectra: fine, middling, coarse, and single-value spectra. The approach uses the 0D flow model, with changes only to the neutron source energy spectra. The fine, middling, and coarse spectra include the full incident neutron energy spectra but with different bin sizes. The single-value spectra include several categories: neutron energy classification, mean energy, and median energy. The neutron energy classification is provided in Table 5.3, recreated from [109]. The study will also examine hand-crafted spectra where the mean and median remain unchanged, but the spectrum itself varies.

Table 5.3: Classification of neutron energy categories by energy range from [109].

Category	Energy Range [MeV]
Cold	$< 3 \times 10^9$
Thermal	$3 \times 10^9 - 4 \times 10^7$
Epithermal	$4 \times 10^7 - 1 \times 10^4$
Intermediate	$1 \times 10^4 - 2 \times 10^{-1}$
Fast	$2 \times 10^{-1} - 1 \times 10^1$
Relativistic	$> 1 \times 10^1$

This sensitivity study will determine the necessary level of detail in the incident neutron energy spectrum for generating DNP group parameters. For example, this analysis can investigate if the spectral effects of refueling is sufficiently great to warrant updates to the improved DNP group parameters. Organizing by category or mean energy is expected to suffice for most cases. For cases where this approach is inadequate, a more robust method can be selectively applied.